

Chapter 5 - First Meeting

Father Feng and Mother Feng were delighted that Feng Yue could come home to stay for a few days, and that very evening they prepared many dishes that Feng Yue loved to eat.

Seeing her parents' enthusiasm while her appetite had not yet recovered, Feng Yue really couldn't bring herself to refuse.

After dinner, Feng Yue went alone to her upstairs room. Looking at the room where she had lived since childhood, with everything unchanged, she couldn't help but feel her nose tingle with emotion.

How could she have been so confused in her previous life? She had wasted a full twelve years on Yan Lin.

In the end, she didn't even have a friend she could ask to go shopping with.

Thinking carefully, her first encounter with Yan Lin had begun with that cultural performance that shouldn't have belonged to her.

Twelve years ago, at Poyuan Private Middle School¹.

Class 7 of Grade 8 was in chaos, with the cultural committee member standing on the podium with a flushed face, begging for someone to help her.

Next Friday evening was their school's annual anniversary gala. Originally, each class was supposed to perform one act, and their class had decided on a folk dance solo by Zhou Qiongqiong, the prettiest girl in their class.

But this morning, their homeroom teacher suddenly came to tell her that there were too many acts for the gala, so the grade committee had decided to merge their class's act with Class 1's piano solo.

Proud and arrogant Zhou Qiongqiong naturally didn't want anyone else stealing her spotlight at the gala, so she went directly to the cultural committee member and announced her withdrawal.

In a private middle school where all the children were from wealthy or powerful families, when Zhou Qiongqiong made up her mind not to perform, even the teachers were helpless.

Mainly because her reason was sufficient enough.

"How can folk dance be merged with a piano solo? That's too weird! I'm not performing!"

Just like that, Zhou Qiongqiong completely withdrew.

This led to the anxious scene of the cultural committee member standing helplessly on the podium.

Fourteen-year-old Feng Yue sat in the classroom, currently chewing on her pen tip while thinking about problems out of boredom. Suddenly, she felt her deskmate bump into her.

"What's wrong?" Feng Yue looked up.

Her female deskmate leaned over and said quietly: "I'm really speechless about Zhou Qiongqiong. She insisted on monopolizing our class's performance slot before and even tattled to ruin our drama. Now she says she won't perform. The cultural committee member is so pitiful."

"Didn't she say she wanted to do a solo dance? She's not dancing anymore?"

"Right, just because the grade committee said they wanted to merge her act with Class 1's piano solo, she's not dancing anymore."

Hearing this, Feng Yue had to admire the grade committee's brilliant idea—piano with folk dance, how ingenious of them.

Feng Yue twirled her pen while listening to her deskmate's complaints, occasionally chiming in with agreement.

But as they talked, her deskmate looked sympathetically at the cultural committee member still standing on the podium and sighed: "Sigh, why don't you go dance instead?"

Feng Yue looked at her in astonishment: "Are you kidding me? Me? Dance what? A ritual dance²?"

"Ballet! Didn't you learn it? I remember you studied it for quite a while."

"Where's the 'quite a while'? I only studied until elementary school ended. That's simply not something a human can dance. Besides, with my half-baked skills, performing on stage would make people laugh their teeth off."

Her deskmate chatted with her cheerfully for a few more sentences, but perhaps the cultural committee member was too desperate, because their not-very-loud discussion was entirely overheard by her.

The cultural committee member was at her wit's end. She suddenly locked her gaze onto Feng Yue's face, then walked from the podium to Feng Yue's seat in three quick steps.

Feng Yue was startled by the cultural committee member's sudden appearance, and then the committee member began tearfully pleading with her.

Feng Yue was naturally soft-hearted, and the cultural committee member was usually quiet and didn't talk much. Now she stood there looking pitiful.

In any case, Feng Yue didn't know why, but she somehow agreed in a daze.

It wasn't until after school when the cultural committee member grabbed her and rushed toward the art classroom that she suddenly came to her senses.

But before she could break free from the cultural committee member's grip and flee, the door to the art classroom in front of them was opened from inside.

She still remembered it was around 4 PM, with the setting sun streaming in through the windows, dyeing the entire classroom an orange-red color.

And right in the middle of this orange-red space, a girl in school uniform sat properly at a dark brown piano, her gaze calmly looking toward her from afar.

Feng Yue, who had originally wanted to escape, somehow found her feet nailed to the ground as if she couldn't move at all.

It wasn't until the cultural committee member tugged her sleeve for the third time that she was pulled back to reality.

The person who opened the door for them was Class 1's cultural committee member, and the girl sitting inside was naturally the one who would perform with Zhou Qiongqiong in this merged act.

No wonder—performing with such a beautiful person, even Zhou Qiongqiong would be overshadowed.

Feng Yue quietly gazed at the other's serene face, thinking this.

"Hello, you can choose whatever music you need. I can play anything," said the girl sitting at the piano.

"*Letzter Tag*³," Feng Yue murmured.

The two cultural committee members looked confused, and even that girl quietly looked toward Feng Yue.

Feng Yue suddenly came back to her senses, blinked, and fumblingly took out her phone to play the song for them to hear.

Watching Feng Yue step forward to chat with the person, the cultural committee member finally breathed a sigh of relief.

Women! She was clearly the one I dragged to the art classroom, but she had already thought of the performance piece.

However, being able to successfully solve this problem, the cultural committee member was filled with immense gratitude toward Feng Yue.

The cultural committee member felt wonderful, but Feng Yue felt not so great at the time.

A knock at the door interrupted Feng Yue's memories. She put aside the photo album she had been searching through in her storage box and got up to open the door.

The person knocking was Mother Feng, holding a cup of hot milk in her hands, casually asking: "Nuan nuan, what were you looking at? It took you so long to open the door."

Feng Yue hesitated, and before she could speak, Mother Feng saw the photo album she had casually placed aside.

Mother Feng smiled teasingly: "You really can't be away from A-Lin for even a moment. You barely come home for one night and you're already in your room looking at her photos."

Feng Yue felt somewhat at a loss. Blinking, she followed Mother Feng's gaze and discovered that the photo album was open to a page showing a candid shot of her and Yan Lin performing at the gala.

The background was their school's auditorium, with only the two of them on stage plus a pure white grand piano.

Two spotlights shone down from above their heads. Yan Lin's seaweed-like long curls gleamed under the lights, and her light blue gauzy dress elevated her to an untouchable position, like a snow lotus blooming on a snowy mountain.

Under the other spotlight was Feng Yue, her long hair pinned entirely back, her pure black fitted ballet costume perfectly showcasing her slender, delicate waist, looking exactly like a ballet dancer from a music box.

Mother Feng placed the milk on the table and smiled as she sat beside Feng Yue, picking up the photo from the album.

"I remember, this is when you started pestering A-Lin, isn't it?"

Feng Yue was silent for a moment, then finally nodded nostalgically.

Yes, she had started pursuing Yan Lin after that gala.

The fourteen-year-old girl's first awakening of love was like the explosion of an eternal planet in the universe.

She still remembered that to coordinate well with each other, she and Yan Lin spent almost all their free time in the art classroom during the week before the gala.

Yan Lin was someone who demanded perfection from herself. Whatever she was responsible for, she would definitely do perfectly.

Feng Yue seemed to be influenced by her. During that week, besides the usual school supplies, her backpack also contained a pair of pointe shoes she hadn't worn for almost two years.

This dance was Feng Yue's favorite, and also the one she had practiced most.

With both of them working so hard, the final result naturally didn't disappoint.

Their collaborative performance caused a huge sensation at the gala that day.

It was from that time that Yan Lin completely moved into Feng Yue's heart.

Looking back now, the piece she had chosen then was truly fitting.

A song the composer wrote to commemorate his deceased wife, and in the end, she too became Yan Lin's deceased wife.

Mother Feng didn't stay in her room for too long. After chatting with her for a while, she left.

As a patient, Feng Yue naturally wouldn't stay up late. She carefully put the photo back in the album, then tucked the album back into the bottom of the storage box where it couldn't see daylight.

She couldn't bear to throw away the beautiful times she had spent with Yan Lin, but she also didn't want to see those photos that recorded their years together anymore.

So she could only seal all those memories and photos in darkness where they couldn't see the light.

Perhaps because the memories were too profound, that night Feng Yue dreamed of her fourteen-year-old self again.

After that gala ended, Feng Yue and Yan Lin formed a kind of wonderful friendship, but this wasn't the biggest change in their school life.

The biggest change was the continuous stream of love letters and small gifts that appeared in both their desks.

Poyuan Private Middle School could be said to be Beijing's most luxurious private school, even earning the nickname "backyard garden of wealthy families" among outsiders.

The children studying there all came from families with power, influence, or money. They happened to be at the age of thirteen or fourteen, when they were most curious about matters of love.

The suddenly famous Feng Yue and Yan Lin were the perfect targets for them to project their emotions onto.

Poyuan Middle School didn't require students to eat lunch in the cafeteria, so many parents chose to have their housekeepers deliver meals to their children at noon.

Mother Feng was naturally one of them.

However, Feng Yue had been so annoyed by those so-called pursuers these past few days that after getting her lunch, instead of going to the cafeteria, she carried her food container alone, taking several detours to reach the rooftop of the laboratory building.

Sometimes Feng Yue really regretted taking on this collaborative performance mess. If she hadn't performed that day, she could now openly write love letters, give gifts, and pursue Yan Lin.

Instead of now having to hide like avoiding a plague, dodging those students who deliberately tried to chat her up.

However, Feng Yue was quite philosophical about it. She now barely had some connection with Yan Lin. As the saying goes, "the pavilion closest to the water gets the moon first"⁴—this was also the only benefit this performance had brought her.

Thinking this, Feng Yue reached out to push open the rooftop door, and saw Yan Lin, who like her, had come to the rooftop to eat and hide from people.

Footnotes:

¹ Poyuan Private Middle School (珀元私立中学) - A fictional elite private school. "Poyuan" combines 珀 (amber/precious stone) and 元 (origin/beginning), suggesting exclusivity and high status.

² Ritual dance (跳大神) - A colloquial and humorous reference to shamanic or folk religious dancing. Feng Yue is being self-deprecating, suggesting she'd look ridiculous dancing.

³ *Letzter Tag* - German for "Last Day." This appears to be a melancholic classical piece, fitting the tragic undertones of the story.

⁴ "The pavilion closest to the water gets the moon first" (近水楼台先得月) - A Chinese idiom meaning that those in favorable positions have advantages, similar to "proximity breeds opportunity."